The East German leader, Walter Ulbricht, had a solution: surrounding West Berlin with a wall. That, however, was a difficult proposition. First, East and West Berlin constituted a joint railway hub without which the East German economy would grind to a halt. Second, the Soviet leaders and their allies in Czechoslovakia and Hungary were concerned that the construction of a wall would be followed by an economic blockade of the whole Eastern bloc, making their economic situation worse and necessitating greater Soviet subsidies. Ulbricht did not care, and by May 1961 he had another argument in his favor: his work crews had completed the construction of an outer ring railroad. West Berlin could now be cut off from the eastern part of the city without hurting the East German economy. All he needed now was Khrushchev's go-ahead. But Khrushchev vacillated, hoping to browbeat Kennedy into submission.[23]

On August 1, six days after Kennedy's speech, Khrushchev told Ulbricht that he could start building the wall. Less than two weeks later, in the early morning of Sunday, August 13, the East German army and border police sealed off West Berlin and, with the help of construction crews, began to surround it with barbed wire. Khrushchev had proposed making West Berlin a free city: now it was turning into a big concentration camp. He had visited both East and West Berlin before construction began, thinking about the possible American reaction. Kennedy had insisted in Vienna on maintaining American access rights, and Khrushchev had no plans to interfere with them. He also all but buried his plans to sign a peace agreement with East Germany—the wall was supposed to solve his main problem without a treaty. But he remained nervous.[24]

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KENNEDY'S FIRST REACTION TO THE WALL WAS SHOCK, FOLLOWED by a sigh of relief. He had not seen the wall coming, nor had his spies in West Berlin, who missed the preparations for construction. But he soon realized that the wall was not a challenge to the American access rights that he had promised to defend by force. Kennedy approved a State Department announcement that described the construction of the wall as a violation of the four-power